SURVEY REPORT

Emerging Trends in Low-Code Application Development

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Executive Summary

Low-code and no-code (LCNC) development has become an important part of enterprise software strategy. The market is growing quickly as more companies use these platforms to build applications faster and with less coding.

Three major trends are shaping LCNC in 2026. **First** , AI is being added to development tools, allowing users to create apps and workflows using natural language. **Second** , companies are creating stronger governance, training, and security rules for citizen developers. **Third** , the market is splitting between fast, simple AI app-building tools and secure, enterprise-grade platforms.

This report explores these trends, major LCNC platform categories, governance challenges, and the future of low-code development over the next two to three years.

1. Introduction

Low-code development platforms (LCDPs) allow developers and non-developers to build applications using visual tools instead of writing large amounts of code. No-code platforms go further by removing coding completely for simpler use cases. Together, they are known as **low-code/no-code (LCNC)** .

LCNC makes software development faster and easier by providing drag-and-drop tools, reusable components, ready-made integrations, and automated infrastructure. What started mainly for prototypes and simple internal tools has grown into a solution for important business and customer-facing applications.

This report examines the current state of LCNC in 2026, including its growth, major trends, key platforms, and future direction

3. Key Emerging Trends

3.1 AI and Agentic Development

- AI is becoming a core part of low-code platforms.
- Users can describe an app or workflow in **natural language** and generate it automatically.
- AI agents can now perform multi-step tasks and connect with other systems.
- The market is divided between **quick AI prototype tools** and **secure enterprise platforms**.

3.2 Citizen Development

- Business employees can build applications without being professional developers.
- Companies are creating **training, approval processes, and security rules** to control this development.
- This helps reduce uncontrolled **shadow IT** .

3.3 Industry-Specific Platforms

- More platforms are being designed for industries such as **healthcare,banking, insurance, and government** .
- They provide ready-made workflows, data models, and compliance features.

3.4 Composable and Multi-Cloud Architecture

- Low-code platforms are increasingly connected to existing cloud systems, databases, and APIs.
- Companies want platforms that work across **multiple clouds and technologies** .

3.5 Governance and Compliance

Security and governance are becoming major buying factors.

Important features include:

- Role-based Access
- Audit logs
- Version control
- Data protection
- Regulatory compliance

3.6 Workforce Changes

- Low-code reduces the need for routine coding.
- New roles are growing, such as **low-codearchitects,governance managers, and citizen-developer trainers** .
- Developers can focus more on complex and strategic projects.

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4. Platform Landscape

Category	Examples	Main Use
Enterprise platforms	OutSystems, Mendix, Power Apps	Large business applications
Internal tools	Retool, ToolJet, Budibase	Dashboards and admin tools
No-code builders	Bubble, Adalo, Glide	Simple web/mobile apps
AI app builders	Lovable, Bolt.new, v0, Replit	Fast prototypes
Automation platforms	Zapier, Make, n8n	Workflow automation
AI agent platforms	Copilot Studio, Dify, Vellum	AI agents and automation

Companies often use **multiple platforms** for different needs.

5. Governance and Risks

Major challenges include:

- **Shadow IT:** Employees may create applications without IT approval.
- **Security risks:** Sensitive data may be handled incorrectly.
- **Scalability:** Some platforms may struggle with very complex applications.
- **Vendor lock-in:** Moving applications to another platform can be difficult.
- **Integration:** Connecting with existing business systems can be complicated.
- **Lack of training:** Citizen developers may not understand security or architecture requirements.

Successful organizations usually use **clear rules, training, approval processes, testing environments, and monitoring** .

6. Benefits of LCNC

- **Faster development and deployment**
- **Lower development costs**
- **Less pressure on professional developers**
- **More employees can build solutions**
- **Faster response to business needs**
- Allows developers to focus on **complex and strategic work**

Low-codeisgenerally **not replacing professional developers**.Instead, it handles simpler applications whiledevelopersfocus onmoreadvancedsystems.

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7. Outlook: 2026 and Beyond

Over the next 2–3 years:

- AI-based app creation will become standard.
- AI agents will handle more business tasks.
- Governance and security will become more important.
- AI prototype tools and enterprise platforms will remain separate categories.
- Industry-specific platforms will continue to grow.
- New hybrid roles combining business and technical skills will increase.

8. Conclusion

Low-code and no-code have moved from simple productivity tools to an important part of enterprise software development. **AI, automation, and citizen development** will continue driving growth.

However, companies need strong **security, governance, training, and architecture** to use LCNC successfully. The future of low-code will depend not only on how quickly people can build applications, but also on how well organizations can **control and manage them** .

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